

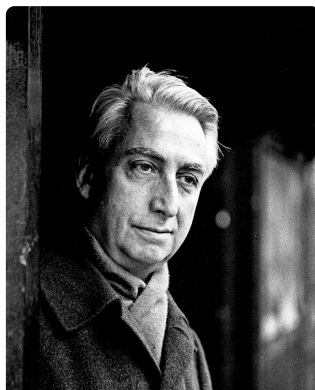
How do Anthropologists Ask Questions about Food?



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Food is a human universal; all people eat, and everyone has an opinion about what they eat (and what they don't)! As a result, anthropologists have always been concerned with food as a central and common human experience. Food is a topic that transcends subfield: People build rituals and social relationships around food, primates spend much of their time foraging for food, people talk about food and even develop language out of food ("That idea is half-baked!"), and archaeologists find literal mounds of ancient food waste (<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Midden>) that can define specific ancient cultures. So the question is never "Why study food?" but rather, "How do anthropologists study food?"

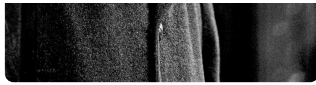
The questions that anthropologists ask about food are diverse and have changed and developed as research approaches have changed across the history of anthropology. To introduce you to some of the approaches used by anthropologists of the past, who have shaped much of the way that we think about food today, you have been assigned four readings from the supplementary volume *Food and Culture: A Reader*, and one chapter from *The Slow and the Slow Cooked: Culture and Barbecue in the Mid-South*. This book includes excerpts of previously written articles and books by anthropologists, primarily sociocultural anthropologists, from the early 20th century through the present. I have selected chapters by Roland Barthes (originally published in 1961), Claude Lévi-Strauss (1966), and Marvin Harris (1985) to represent foundational texts in the field. We will also read two more contemporary pieces, by Psyche Williams-Forson (2008) and by James Veteto and Edward Maclin (2011), that provide a lens for how contemporary anthropologists perceive the role of food in the study of anthropology. If you haven't read these yet, stop here and read the five articles, and consider the reading questions provided for each; then come back to the next page. Discussion of these readings is also the focus of our Live Classroom this week.



Roland Barthes, in 1979

Source: [Chicago Tribune](#)

(<https://www.chicagotribune.com/2013/03/08/revisiting-roland-barthes-mythologies-2/>)



Claude Lévi-Strauss,
in 2005

Source: Wikimedia Commons
(https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Levi-strauss_260.jpg)



Marvin Harris, photo undated

Source: New World Encyclopedia
(https://www.newworldencyclopedia.org/entry/Marvin_Harris)



Psyche Williams-Forsen, photo undated

Source: University of Maryland
(<https://anth.umd.edu/facultyprofile/williams-forsen/psyche>)



James Veteto, photo undated

Source: Personal Website (<https://jrveteto.wixsite.com/jimveteto>)



Edward Maclin, photo undated

Source: Personal Website (<https://uga.academia.edu/TedMaclin>)

